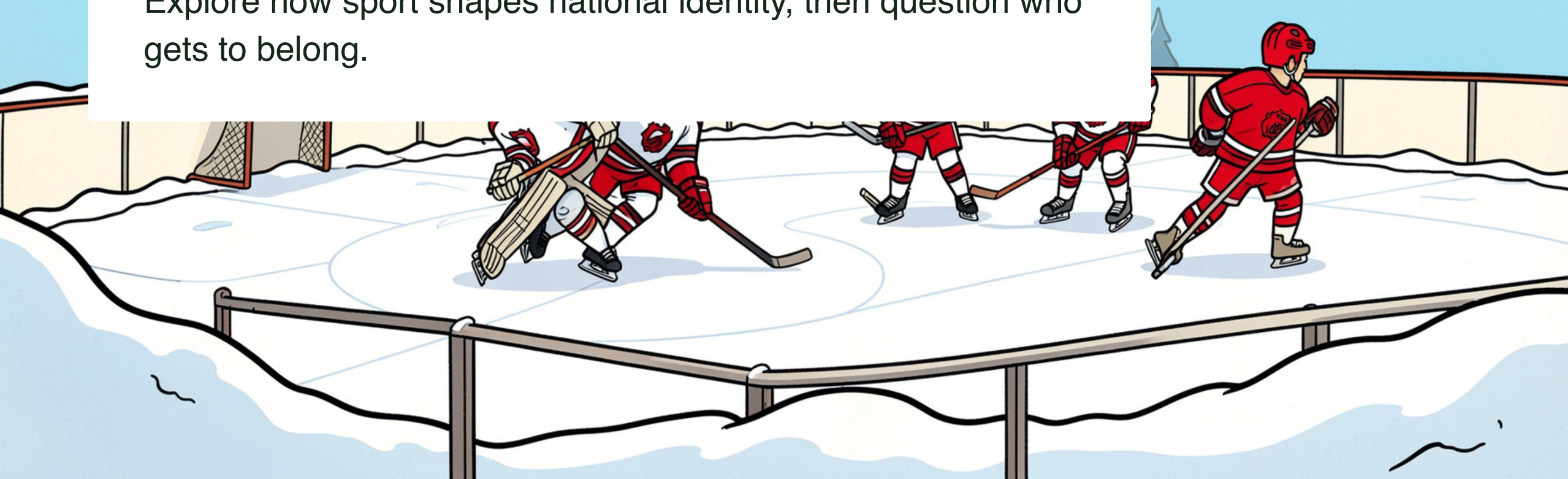
DEBATE · CANADA

HOCKEY: CANADA'S RELIGION — OR JUST A GAME?

Explore how sport shapes national identity, then question who gets to belong.



WHEN SPORT BECOMES IDENTITY



What sport is shown?

Which country is famous for it?

Why can sport matter to a country’s identity?

VOCABULARY

FIVE WORDS FOR TODAY'S DEBATE



passion

strong enthusiasm



national sport

a country's most popular cultural sport



religion

faith and worship, or deep devotion metaphorically



identity

who we are as a people



rivalry

intense competition

PREDICT BEFORE YOU READ

Some people call hockey a “religion” in Canada.

Do you expect the text to **defend** that idea, **challenge** it, or do both?

PERSPECTIVE 1

HOCKEY CREATES BELONGING

For many Canadians, hockey is part of the national soul.

Fans feel awe and belonging to a larger community.

Children may learn to skate before they learn to read.

The 1972 Summit Series became a drama of national identity, pride, politics, and ideology.

Olympic victories can unite people across regions, languages, and backgrounds.





PERSPECTIVE 2

HOCKEY CAN EXCLUDE PEOPLE

Equipment, ice time, and travel can make hockey very expensive.

Equipping one child can cost about **$800**.

Low-income and immigrant families may not be able to afford to play.

Critics describe hockey as an “elite sport.”

The stereotype of a young, able-bodied, white male player can make others feel excluded.

READ FOR DETAIL: FIND THE EVIDENCE

Underline one sentence that supports each answer.

01

Why do academics compare hockey to a religion?

02

What did the 1972 Summit Series represent?

03

How much can basic equipment cost?

04

Why do critics call hockey an elite sport?

05

Who is missing from the typical-player image?

COMPARE

COMPLETE THE COMPARISON

Question	Religion view	Just-a-game view
Main idea	Hockey creates belonging.	Hockey can exclude people.
Evidence	Examples of passion, identity, rivalry, and national pride.	Facts about cost, access, and the typical-player image.
Who belongs?	Fans across regions, languages, and backgrounds.	Some people may be left out.

Which argument is stronger? What evidence makes it convincing?

ROUND-TABLE DEBATE

CAN A SPORT BE A RELIGION?



Belonging

Why do people need sport to feel awe and belonging?



Faith

Can sport replace traditional religion?



Access

If hockey is too expensive, is it still a national sport?



Responsibility

Should public money help children play?

“From my point of view…”

“I see your point, but…”

YOUR COUNTRY

Popular sport

What is the most popular sport in your country?

Unity

Does it unite people across differences?

Access

Is it accessible to everyone, or becoming an elite sport?

Learning

What can Canada learn from your country — and vice versa?

YOUR TURN

Give one comparison and one example.